

Youth Action Conference — Code of Conduct

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The **Youth Action Conference (YAC)** brings together young people, speakers, facilitators, and organizers from different countries, cultures, backgrounds, and perspectives.

YAC is designed to encourage **open conversation, respectful disagreement, curiosity, collaboration, and action**. Everyone who takes part has a responsibility to help create an environment where people can participate safely and meaningfully.

This Code of Conduct applies to **participants, speakers, moderators, facilitators, volunteers, organizers, and guests**.

1. Our Core Expectation

Challenge ideas. Respect people.

YAC welcomes debate. Participants are **not expected to agree** with one another.

You may question an argument, challenge an assumption, disagree with a speaker, criticize a policy, or introduce a very different perspective.

Do so without attacking, humiliating, intimidating, or demeaning another person.

Strong ideas can be challenged strongly. People should still be treated with dignity.

2. Expected Conduct

Everyone participating in YAC is expected to:

- Treat others with respect, including when you disagree.
- Listen without deliberately interrupting or dominating conversations.
- Give others opportunities to contribute.
- Use respectful and appropriate language.
- Engage with different perspectives in good faith.
- Follow reasonable instructions from moderators and organizers.
- Respect different communication and participation styles.

- Respect participants' privacy and personal boundaries.
- Ask before sharing another person's story, image, or information.
- Use conference platforms and communication channels appropriately.
- Help create an environment in which people feel able to ask questions and make mistakes.
- Raise concerns when something appears unsafe or inappropriate.

3. Unacceptable Conduct

The following behavior is not acceptable at YAC:

Harassment or discrimination based on a person's identity, background, nationality, ethnicity, race, religion, disability, gender, sexual orientation, age, language, or other personal characteristic.

Bullying or intimidation, including repeated hostile comments, deliberate humiliation, threats, unwanted targeting, or attempts to silence another participant.

Hate speech or language that promotes hatred, violence, or dehumanization of people or groups.

Sexual harassment or inappropriate sexual behavior, including unwanted sexual comments, messages, images, advances, or requests.

Deliberate disruption, including trolling, spamming, repeatedly interrupting sessions, impersonating another person, or interfering with conference technology.

Privacy violations, including sharing someone's private information, messages, contact details, photographs, or recordings without appropriate permission.

Unauthorized recording. Participants must not independently record conference sessions, breakout rooms, or private conversations without permission.

Retaliation against someone who raises a concern or reports inappropriate behavior in good faith.

4. Online Conduct

YAC is a virtual conference, so these expectations also apply to online spaces associated with the event.

Participants must not:

- Share private conference links publicly.
- Invite unregistered people into conference sessions.

- Record or screenshot other participants without permission.
- send inappropriate private messages;
- deliberately display offensive or sexually explicit material;
- use screen sharing, chat, reactions, usernames, backgrounds, or profile images to harass or disrupt;
- attempt to obtain unnecessary personal information from other participants.

Keep your display name recognizable to conference organizers.

Where possible, communicate through official YAC spaces rather than moving conversations involving young participants into private channels.

5. Young Participants & Safeguarding

YAC is a **youth-centered conference and may include participants under 18.**

Everyone must maintain appropriate boundaries when interacting with young participants.

Adults, speakers, organizers, and older participants have a particular responsibility to model appropriate conduct.

YAC must not be used to:

- pursue sexual or romantic interactions with minors;
- solicit inappropriate private communication;
- request intimate or inappropriate photographs;
- pressure young people to disclose personal information;
- arrange inappropriate private meetings;
- solicit money, purchases, or financial transactions from young participants;
- exploit a position of authority, influence, or trust.

Where practical, communication between YAC representatives and minors should take place through **official, transparent conference channels.**

A safeguarding concern should be referred to the designated YAC safeguarding contact rather than investigated informally by participants.

6. Privacy & Personal Information

Respect other people's right to decide what they share.

Do not pressure participants to disclose their:

- exact age or date of birth;

- address or location;
- telephone number;
- personal social-media accounts;
- medical information;
- family circumstances;
- political or religious beliefs;
- experiences of trauma;
- or other private information.

A participant choosing to discuss a personal experience during a session does **not** give others permission to share that experience elsewhere.

7. Accessibility & Inclusion

Different people participate in different ways.

A participant may:

- keep their camera off;
- communicate through chat;
- need additional processing time;
- use captions or assistive technology;
- take breaks;
- leave and rejoin;
- choose not to speak;
- require written instructions;
- use language support;
- participate with assistance.

Do not question, mock, challenge, or demand an explanation for someone's reasonable accessibility adjustment.

Participants are not required to disclose a diagnosis to justify their way of participating.

8. Sensitive Discussions

YAC may address challenging subjects, including human rights, conflict, discrimination, inequality, political systems, health, and other global issues.

These conversations can involve strong disagreement.

Participants should distinguish between:

challenging an idea and **attacking a person**.

For example:

- ✓ “I disagree with that argument because...”
- ✓ “Could you explain the evidence behind that position?”
- ✓ “That policy could affect this community differently...”

Rather than:

- ✗ “Anyone who believes that is stupid.”
- ✗ Personal insults, threats, or discriminatory comments.

Moderators may intervene when a discussion becomes personal, unsafe, discriminatory, or excessively disruptive.

9. Images, Screenshots & Recording

YAC organizers may photograph, screenshot, or record designated parts of the conference.

Participants will be informed when official recording is taking place.

Individual participants must **not independently record or screenshot other participants without permission**.

Where a participant has indicated that they do not consent to public use of their image or name, organizers should take reasonable steps to respect that choice.

10. Reporting a Concern

If something happens that makes you or another participant feel unsafe or violates this Code of Conduct, you can contact:

YAC Safeguarding / Conduct Contact

[NAME OR ROLE]

[EMAIL ADDRESS]

You can also privately contact a YAC moderator or organizer during the conference.

You do **not** need to confront the person yourself.

When reporting something, provide only the information you are comfortable sharing. Organizers may need to ask additional questions when necessary to understand or respond to a serious concern.

11. How YAC Will Respond

Not every problem requires the same response.

Depending on the seriousness, context, and pattern of behavior, YAC organizers may:

1 — REMIND

Clarify expectations or ask someone to change their behavior.

2 — WARN

Issue a clear warning that the behavior must stop.

3 — RESTRICT

Mute someone, disable chat or other functions, move them from a session, restrict private communication, or limit participation.

4 — REMOVE

Remove someone from a session or the conference.

5 — ESCALATE

For serious safeguarding, safety, or legal concerns, organizers may need to involve a parent/guardian, responsible organization, platform provider, safeguarding professional, or appropriate authority.

Serious behavior can result in **immediate removal without progressing through every stage**.

12. Good-Faith Reporting

Anyone may raise a concern.

YAC will not tolerate retaliation against someone for making a report in good faith, supporting someone who raises a concern, or participating in a safeguarding or conduct process.

Reports should be handled as privately as reasonably possible. However, YAC cannot promise absolute confidentiality when information must be shared to protect someone's safety or respond appropriately to a serious concern.

13. Responsibility of Speakers & Organizers

This Code applies to the YAC team too.

Speakers, moderators, and organizers are expected to:

- model respectful dialogue;
- avoid abusing positions of authority;
- maintain appropriate boundaries with young participants;
- respond appropriately to concerns;
- avoid pressuring participants to disclose personal experiences;
- make reasonable efforts to support accessibility;
- distinguish personal opinions from official YAC positions where relevant;
- handle participant information responsibly.

Being a speaker, organizer, partner, or invited guest does not exempt anyone from these expectations.

14. Agreement to Participate

By participating in the Youth Action Conference, you agree to follow this Code of Conduct and reasonable instructions given by YAC organizers to maintain a safe and constructive event.

The purpose isn't to prevent difficult conversations.

It's to make difficult conversations **possible**.

Be curious. Challenge ideas. Respect people. Make space for others. Take action.